

STAMPEDED DREAMS

POLITICS

Dear Osagyefo,

I know it's always misery after misery whenever I have to write to you. Frankly, some of my friends who read my last letter begged me not to bother you with another one, but this one, I'm afraid, is newsworthy. Just a few days ago, we received the report on the gentle souls who perished in that helicopter crash. Before we could even catch our breath, tragedy decided to pay another visit. Apparently, last year, the military decided to sell recruitment forms for 350 Ghana cedis each. About 90,000 desperate young people, jobless, hopeful, and clutching dreams, bought those forms. That's roughly 31.5 million cedis made off the unemployed, all to recruit just 3,000 people. In other words, only 0.3 percent made it in. And then today, as if on cue, thousands once again converged at the El Wak Stadium, men and women alike, chasing the same dream. When the gates opened, the human wave surged, and six young women lost their lives in the stampede, many injured and a few in critical condition. Six souls gone, just trying to get a job. They left their homes at dawn, full of hope and promise. Their families prayed they'd return safely. A stampede was the last thing anyone imagined. Mind you, this year's process was supposedly discounted. Applications were online. You could buy an e-voucher at the post office or dial a short code and pay 200 cedis. You'd get a pin, fill out your form, and then, because this is Ghana, you'd still have to show up in person under the blazing sun, praying not to be trampled. Physical appearance, not intellect, remains the main criteria. You'd think the army would at least test for brainpower before letting people carry guns. But then again, it wasn't long ago that a uniformed military man was filmed beating a woman and pharmacy attendant at a pharmacy in the most barbaric way imaginable.

We must channel this strength, this collective grief and outrage, into building safeguards that ensure such a tragedy never happens again. The military, after all, is held to a higher standard; we look to them for discipline, precision, and dignity. Yet today, we saw none of that. Instead, hopeful young people were made to sit on bare floors, stand in endless queues under the sun, and endure indignities, all in the name of measuring bodies and checking papers.

To add insult to injury, a senior military officer appeared to "set the record straight" with all the emotional intelligence of a stone. People's children have died through the military's negligence, yet her only concern was statistics. No apology. No condolences. Not even a flicker of empathy. Madam, even one death from this exercise is one too many, a needless, avoidable tragedy. Soon, as tradition demands, a "committee" will be formed. They'll sit, eat, collect allowances, and after a few months, produce a fine report for the archives, to be shelved next to the others gathering dust. And the cycle continues.

Yours in frustration,

Ato_KD